

fictional story running in the background. A fictional story such as ‘confidence’ in the overall market is important for industrialists and economists while charting expansion plans. A fictional story that ‘*The World’s Happiest Man*’ (read Matthieu Ricard ^[1]) exists and is safely locked in the mountains while we can remain unhappy because we live in faraway cities. A fictional story of a burger that would taste great when you look at the sauce drooling out from the pictures, but will never taste the same when you have it.

In certain instances, this fictional story has benefited us. Yuval Noah Harari ^[2] would point out that the reason homo sapiens survived eons while other species didn’t, is because they could communicate things like, ‘*yesterday I saw a lion drinking water and so today it might come too. Let’s take this other route.*’ This ability to conjure stories had stood us in good stead for centuries. But perhaps, right now the tables have turned. Perhaps our ability to create and transpire fictional stories has led too many of us to believe ‘*I have a calling in life*’ and I’m willing to pursue it. Much like outdated religious practices that don’t make sense but we follow them nonetheless for the sole reason that people did for years before us, entrepreneurship mushroomed into the psyches of a larger audience. When word about successful entrepreneurialism started moving, the masses caught wind: “*Maybe I’m not meant for the cubicle and I could do something on my own*”.

And yet, for all the right reasons to join a startup or found one, people started doing it for the wrong reasons.

Reason #1: “You needn’t worry about money. ESOPs will take care of you”

When a few of my friends moved into start-ups upon learning the glorious million-dollar pay-day stories, it proved a modern-day example of the old adage, ‘*With ignorance comes egregious mistakes*’ . Maybe they haven’t read Michael Lewis’ ‘The New New Thing’. Or maybe they believed they are the outliers that Malcolm Gladwell writes on. Outlier considerations aside, the widely prevailing opinion was “*I just have to work hard and the seniors will notice me, which will translate into options pretty soon.*”

VC’s (Venture Capitalists) are notorious for not parting with any amount of equity and quite often, the initial founders can be found with less than 15% of their own company. What is less public is the fact that employees almost never see their share of the pie increasing, even after years of meaningful contribution to the company. Promotions are rare and random and if the company is not doing good on the hockey stick growth, the low salary received now hurts more along with the worthless equity in your hand.

Reason #2: “If you were early at finding a well-heeled horse, you’ll be in the top brass very soon”

Most companies rate top-level, internal promotion as the last on their list of priorities. When the company is looking to hire a wise head, who’s *been there, done that* , they look outside for candidates and the biggest bargaining chip they have in interview negotiations is a fancy title. Incidentally, I’ve heard companies say, “*I hope you know that we can’t offer the salary you’d make at Microsoft but here you’ll be Chief Technology Officer. That will give you the clout you’ll not find anywhere.*” To attract good talent, they **have** to